TURKEY AND MUSHROOM STEW
WITH SASSAFRAS AND PINE BROTH

serves 4 to 6

Sassafras has a long history of medicinal and culinary use in the Southeast. Tribes, including the Cherokee, Choctaw, and Seminole, make tea and other medicines from the roots and bark to resolve respiratory and digestive illnesses or just to enjoy. The flavor of the infusion is reminiscent of a popular drink—root beer—because sassafras roots were one of the components of its original recipe.

The Choctaw people also historically used the leaves, pounding them to thicken and flavor soups. Today, those pounded leaves are known as filé, a popular ingredient in gumbo (see page 144). Here, I use both the roots and leaves in this dusky stew of turkey leg meat and earthy dried and fresh mushrooms, flavored with elements of the forest.

- 2 fresh sassafras roots from saplings (see Note), cleaned, or 1 teaspoon dried sassafras bark
- 1 tablespoon coarsely chopped Virginia pine needles or white pine needles (see Conifers, page 22)
- 1 ounce dried mixed wild mushrooms
- 3 cups boiling water
- 3 tablespoons sunflower oil
- 1 large whole turkey leg (leg and thigh), or 2 turkey thighs or 3 turkey drumsticks
- Sea salt
- 1 large yellow onion, chopped
- 3 large garlic cloves, thinly sliced
- 1 large carrot, scrubbed well and chopped
- 1 cup very thinly sliced fresh wild mushrooms, such as oyster or hen of the woods
- 1 heaping teaspoon filé powder
- ¼ cup tender wild greens (such as chickweed, lamb's quarters, plantain, dandelion, or wood sorrel), coarsely chopped, for garnish
- Corn Mush (optional; page 147), for serving

Combine the sassafras roots and pine needles in a tea bag or in some tied cheesecloth. Place in a large heatproof bowl or liquid measuring cup, add the dried mushrooms and boiling water, and let that steep while you cook the stew.

In a large heavy pot or Dutch oven, heat 2 tablespoons of the oil over medium-high heat until shimmering. Season the turkey with salt and sear it, skin-side down, for 8 to 12 minutes on the first side, until nicely browned and some of its fat has rendered. Flip and cook on the second side for about 8 minutes longer, or until browned. Transfer to a plate.

Reduce the heat to medium and spoon off all but 2 tablespoons of the fat. Add the onion, garlic, and carrot and cook for about 5 minutes, or until the onion is translucent.

Remove the tea bag from the steeping liquid and squeeze out as much liquid as possible. Gradually pour the soaked dried mushrooms and all the soaking liquid into the pot, stopping before you reach the grit that has fallen to the bottom of the bowl or cup.

Return the turkey to the pot. Add more water to the pot as needed so the turkey is about three-quarters submerged. Bring to a boil over high heat. Reduce the heat to medium-low, cover, and simmer for 1½ to 2 hours, until the meat is pulling away from the bone.

Meanwhile, in a skillet, heat the remaining 1 tablespoon of oil over medium-high heat until shimmering. Add the fresh mushrooms and cook for about 8 minutes, stirring, until they release their liquid and start to brown.

Transfer the turkey to a bowl to cool.

Increase the heat under the pot to high and cook until the liquid has thickened and is reduced to about 1½ cups.

Meanwhile, pull the turkey meat from the bones, discarding them, and return the meat to the pot. Add the cooked mushrooms and filé powder and cook, stirring, until the liquid thickens some more.

Serve the stew garnished with wild greens, with the corn mush if desired.

Note: *You can find sassafras trees in certain forests throughout the Eastern woodlands. The trees have three different-shaped leaves and a sweet aroma. They also frequently throw off saplings, which you can dig up for their roots. (Or you can purchase bark and leaves from medicinal herb providers.)*